

LESSON 12

Fringes of Syntax: Demonstratives, Numbers, and Conditionals

SECTION 1: REVIEW OF LESSON 11

Quick Summary

In Lesson 11, we examined how Syriac attaches direct object pronouns directly to the verb, creating a highly compressed “fast direct object” (e.g., *qat̐l-eh*, “he killed him” vs. *q̐tal l-ēh*, “he killed to-him”).

5-Question Warm-Up Drill

(Answers in Section 9)

1. How does Syriac buffer the 1st person singular object suffix on a Peal perfect verb?
 2. Translate: *Parq-anī*.
 3. Break down the components of *qat̐lhūn*.
 4. Why does *q̐tal* become *qat̐l-* when adding a suffix?
 5. Translate the double-determined phrase: *ʾAsyeh Alāhā l-malkā*.
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SECTION 2: DEMONSTRATIVES AND NUMBERS — OVERVIEW

As we wrap up our core tour of Syriac syntax, we encounter the final few connective tissues that hold sentences together: Demonstrative pronouns (this, that, these, those) and Numbers.

Cross-Linguistic Comparison: Demonstratives

Semitic languages feature a close-range pointing word (“this”) and a far-range pointing word (“that”).

- **Hebrew:** זֶה (*zeh* — this, m), הַהוּ (*hahū* ’ — that, m).
- **Arabic:** هَـذَا (*hādhā* — this, m), ذَـلِكَ (*dhālika* — that, m).
- **Syriac:** ܗܢܐ (*hānā* — this, m), ܗܘܐ (*haw* — that, m).

Syriac Trick: The far demonstrative (“that”) is spelled and pronounced exactly like the 3rd person independent pronoun (*hū* = he/it; *haw* = that). Context dictates the meaning.

1. Pointing Words (Demonstratives)

Demonstratives in Syriac must agree with the noun they modify in gender and number. Unlike English (which puts “this” *before* the noun: “this king”), Syriac prefers to place the demonstrative *after* the noun, or even isolated at the front of a sentence.

- *Malkā hānā* = This king (The king, this one).
- *Malkūttā hādē* = This kingdom.
- *Gabrē hāllēn* = These men.

2. Conditional Clauses (**’en**)

Syriac expresses “If X, then Y” using the particle **’en** (if). The “if” half of the sentence is the *protasis*, and the “then” half is the *apodosis*. Usually, Syriac doesn’t even use a word for “then”; it simply starts the second clause, often with **w-** (and).

- *’En teḥzē, teida* ‘ (If you see, [then] you will know).

3. Comparatives (**men**)

Syriac lacks special adjective forms for “bigger,” “faster,” or “better” (like Greek’s -τερος or English’s -er). Instead, it uses the standard adjective and the preposition **men** (from/than).

- *Nūhrā ṭābā hū men ḥešūkā* (Light is good from darkness → Light is **better than** darkness).
- *Rabbā hī men malkūttā* (She is great from the kingdom → She is **greater than** the kingdom).

SECTION 4: DEMONSTRATIVE PRONOUN PARADIGM

DISTANCE	GENDER / NUMBER	ESTRANGELA	TRANSLIT	TRANSLATION
Close	Masc Sg	הָנָא	hānā	this (m)
Close	Fem Sg	הָדֵא	hādē	this (f)
Close	Common Pl	הָלְלֵנ	hāllēn	these (c)
Far	Masc Sg	הָוּ	haw	that (m)
Far	Fem Sg	הָי	hāy	that (f)
Far	Masc Pl	הָנֹנ	hānōn	those (m)
Far	Fem Pl	הָנֵנ	hānēn	those (f)

SECTION 5: THE NUMBERS 1-10

Semitic numbers famously exhibit “gender polarity”—masculine nouns often take what looks like the feminine absolute number ending, and vice versa. However, you only need to recognize them to read them.

NUMBER	MASC FORM (USED WITH FEM NOUNS)	FEM FORM (USED WITH MASC NOUNS)	TRANSLIT
1	אֶחָד (ḥad)	אֶחָדָא (ḥdā)	(One)
2	אַרְבָּע (trēn)	אַרְבָּעָא (tartēn)	(Two)
3	שְׁלֹשָׁה (tlāt)	שְׁלֹשָׁא (tlātā)	(Three)
4	אַרְבַּעַת (‘arba‘)	אַרְבַּעַתָּא (‘arba‘ ā)	(Four)
5	חֲמִשָּׁה (ḥameš)	חֲמִשָּׁא (ḥamšā)	(Five)
6	שֵׁשֶׁת (šet)	שֵׁשֶׁתָּא (štā)	(Six)
7	שְׁבַעַת (šba‘)	שְׁבַעַתָּא (šab‘ ā)	(Seven)
8	תְּמָנָה (tmānē)	תְּמָנָא (tmānyā)	(Eight)
9	תֵּשַׁעַת (tša‘)	תֵּשַׁעַתָּא (teš‘ ā)	(Nine)
10	עָשָׂר (‘sar)	עָשָׂרָא (‘esrā)	(Ten)

The Departure

Narrative note: The conclusion of the initial cycle of Mar Yukhannan's acts. The king uses a conditional statement ("If any man...") to establish a new decree. The section closes with a demonstrative and thematic "peace".

Sentence 1

שדל חלחל מלכא כד אסי-ע' יוֹהָנָן ל-מלכָּה, מלכָּה קָם. kad 'asy-eh Yūḥānnan l-malkā, malkā qām. kad (when) 'asy-eh (he-healed-him) Yūḥānnan (John) l-malkā (to/the-king), malkā (the-king) qām (stood-up). → When Yukhannan healed the king, the king stood up.

Sentence 2

w- 'emar l- 'ammā d-īl-eh hākannā: w- 'emar (and-said) l- 'ammā (to-the-people) d-īl-eh (which-were-his) hākannā (thus): → And he said to his people thus:

Sentence 3

’en ’aynā barnāšā lā nešlah ḥṭtā d-il-eh, neqtlün-yhy! ’en (If) ’aynā (which/any) barnāšā (man) lā (not) nešlah (will-cast-away) ḥṭtā (sin) d-il-eh (which-[is]-his), neqtlün-yhy (they-will-kill-him)! → “If any man does not cast away his sin, they shall kill him!”

Sentence 4

ܝܘܚܢܢ ܝܥܡܪ ܠܡܠܟܐ ܠܐ ܗܝܟܢܢܐ. Yūḥannan 'emar l-malkā: lā hākannā. Yūḥannan (John) 'emar (said) l-malkā
 (to-the-king): lā (not) hākannā (thus/so). → Yukhannan said to the king: "Not so."

Sentence 5

אלהא דשרארה שְׁבַּאק מֵנִי בִישָׂא. Alāhā d-šrārā šbaq men bišā. Alāhā (God) d-šrārā (of-truth) šbaq (forgave) men (from) bišā (evil). → “The God of truth forgave the evil.”

Sentence 6

ܠܗܘܬܐ ܡܢ ܠܗܘܬܐ nūhrā hānā ṭābā hū men ḥešūkā. nūhrā (the-light) hānā (this) ṭābā
(good) hū (it-is) men (from) ḥešūkā (darkness). → “This light is better than darkness.”

Sentence 7

w-šbaq Yūḥannan l-malkūttā b-šlāmā, w-
'ezal b- 'ūrḥā d- 'ālmā. w-šbaq (and-left) Yūḥannan (John) l-malkūttā (the-kingdom) b-šlāmā (in-peace),
w- 'ezal (and-went) b- 'ūrḥā (in-way/road) d- 'ālmā (of-eternity/the-world). → And Yukhannan left the
kingdom in peace, and went in the way of eternity.

SECTION 8: EXERCISES

Exercise 1: Demonstrative & Number Identification

Identify the gender, number, and meaning of these modifiers.

1. ስጋጥ (hādē)
2. ስጋላላ (tlātā)

3. ܚܢܢ (hānōn)

4. ܚܕܐ (ḥdā)

Exercise 2: Comparative Translation

Translate these sentences using **men** as a comparative.

1. Alāhā rabbā hū men malkā.
2. Ḥayyē ṭābīn hennōn men mawtā.
3. 'Ar 'ā hādē bīštā hī men šmayyā (heaven).

Exercise 3: Translation Drill (Syriac → English)

Translate the following conditional and demonstrative clauses.

1. 'En tešbūq l-Alāhā, neqtūl lāk malkā hānā.
2. Gabrā haw npal b-kūrā.
3. W- 'etaw talmīdē hāllēn l-bayteh.
4. Lā hākannā 'emar Yūḥannan b-šrārā.

Exercise 4: Production Drill (English → Syriac)

Render the following sentences into Syriac transliteration.

1. This word (f.sg) is better than that word.
2. If you (m.pl) hear the voice, you will live (ḥ-y-y, imperfect).
3. The three men went out from the kingdom. (Three = *tlātā*).
4. God saved this evil world ('ālmā hānā).

Exercise 5: Reading Comprehension

Re-read Section 7 and answer:

1. What extreme punishment does the king decree for those who do not cast away their sin?
 2. How does Yukhannan correct the king's theology?
 3. With what emotion or state does Yukhannan depart the kingdom?
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Section 1 Warm-Up

1. It inserts a *Nun* (n) buffer, e.g., *qaṭlanī*.
2. Save me! (Imperative).
3. Root *q-ṭ-l* (killed), plus 3rd masc plural suffix *hūn* (them) = He killed them.
4. The addition of the suffix forces a shift in the stress, causing the vowel *a* to move forward (*qṭa-leh* → *qaṭ-leh*).
5. “God healed him, the king” (Double determination using the suffix *and* the preposition *l-*).

Exercise 1: Identification

1. Feminine singular close (This, f)
2. Number three (used with masc nouns)
3. Masculine plural far (Those, m)
4. Number one (f)

Exercise 2: Comparative Translation

1. God is greater than the king.
2. Life is better than death.
3. This earth is worse than heaven.

Exercise 3: Translation Drill

1. If you abandon God, this king will kill you.
2. That man fell into illness.
3. And these disciples came to his house.
4. “Not so” said Yukhannan in truth.

Exercise 4: Production Drill

1. Meltā hādē ṭābtā hī men meltā hāy.
2. ‘En tešm ‘ūn qālā, tēḥūn / teḥyūn.
3. Tlātā gabrīn npaqū men malkūttā.
4. Alāhā praq l- ‘ālmā hānā bīšā.

Exercise 5: Reading Comprehension

1. They will be killed (*neqṭlūn-yhy*).
2. By reminding him that the God of truth forgave the evil (“Not so,” *lā hākannā*).
3. In peace (*b-šlāmā*).

SECTION 10: GRAMMATICAL SUMMARY

DEMONSTRATIVES

CLOSE (THIS / THESE)	FAR (THAT / THOSE)
hānā (m) / hādē (f)	haw (m) / hāy (f)
hāllēn (pl)	hānōn (m.pl) / hānēn (f.pl)

CONDITIONALS & COMPARISONS

CONSTRUCTION	EXAMPLE	MEANING
'en (If) + Imperf	'en teḥzē	If you see...
Adj + <i>men</i> (from)	ṭābā men malkā	Better than the king
Noun + Demonstrative	malkā hānā	This king

SECTION 11: ADDITIONAL VOCABULARY

The following high-frequency words round out this lesson's vocabulary to 8 terms.

SYRIAC (ESTRANGELA)	TRANSLITERATION	PART OF SPEECH	MEANING	NOTES
ܬܪܓܡܐ	tregumā	m. noun	translation	
ܐܝܟܡܐ	'ōkmā	adv	how	relative/interrogative
ܕܡܢ	dumān	adv	from that place	subordinating
ܠܐ	lā	neg_adv	not	negation/discourse
ܡܟܢܬܐ	makknatā	f. noun	place, position	
ܚܕܐ	ḥādyā	m. num	one	first numeral
ܚܡܫܐ	ḥammšā	m. num	five	numeral
ܐܝܠܐ	'esrā	m. num	ten	numeral